

"It is one of the most significant shifts shaping domestic tourism in India today," says Anuraag Bhatnagar, CEO, The Leela Palaces, Hotels and Resorts. "Many guests aren't undertaking short, destination-specific pilgrimages any more. They are extending these journeys to include wellness and cultural exploration creating demand for a more holistic hospitality offering." Leela will be opening a hotel in Ayodhya in 2028.

The trend is visible across the hospitality sector. IHCL, India's largest hospitality company, says spiritual tourism has become a significant growth driver. "We continue to see strong demand from travellers seeking experiences deeply rooted in culture," says Suma Venkatesh, Executive VP, Real Estate and Development. The company has expanded its presence across destinations including Ayodhya, Varanasi, Ajmer, Amritsar, Katra, Haridwar, Rishikesh and Tirupati.

Perhaps nowhere is the transformation more visible than in destinations such as Rishikesh, where spirituality and wellness increasingly overlap. Tarun Gulati, Director of Ganga Kinare Resorts and Hotels, says post-pandemic average room rates in spiritual destinations have doubled, and travellers are willing to pay a premium for experiences such as sound healing, meditation treks and yoga retreats. "Premium and differentiated experiences are experiencing way higher demand and occupancy than the budget segment," he says. Rooms rents have increased 40% to ₹18,000 a night with growing demand.

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